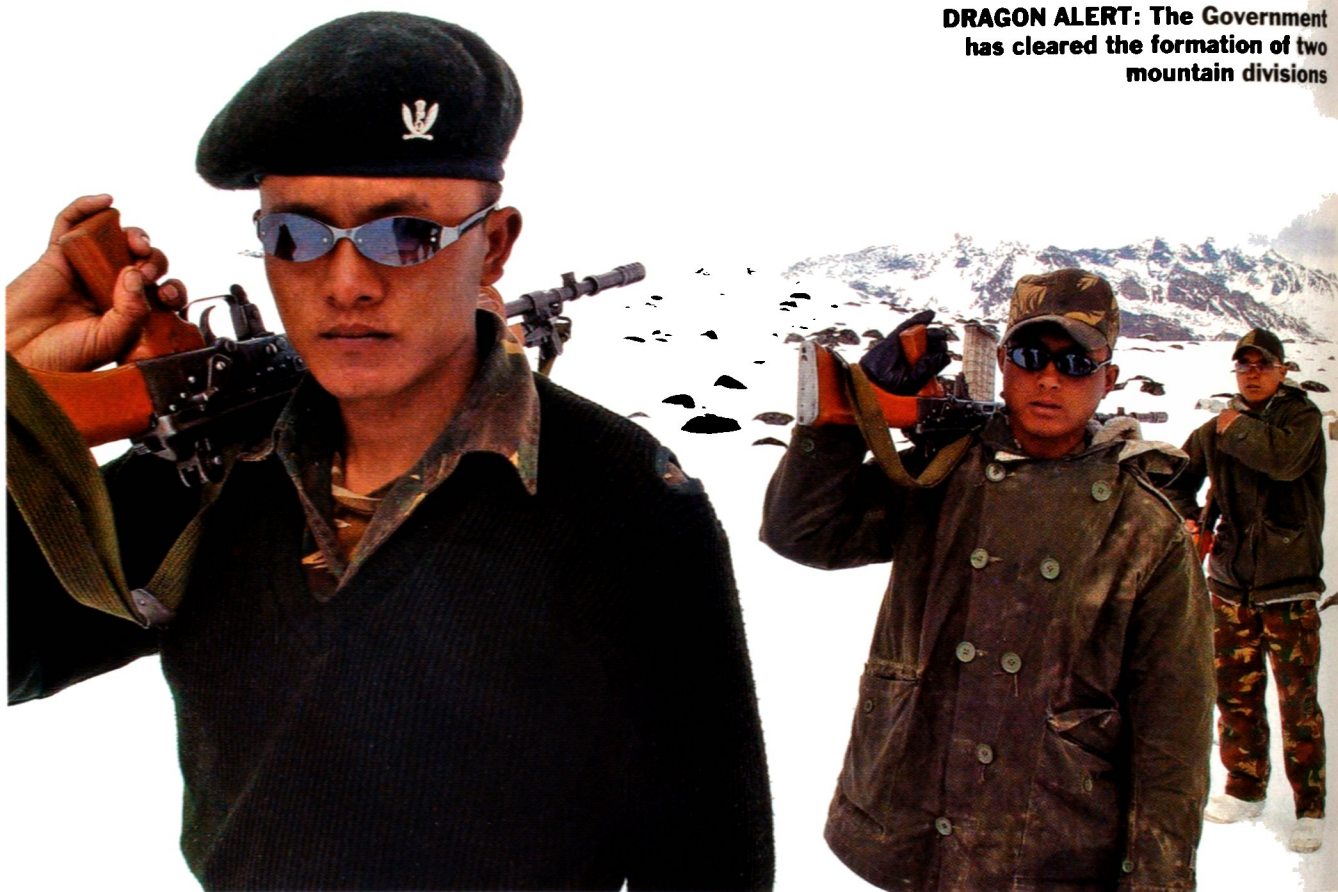


DRAGON ALERT: The Government has cleared the formation of two mountain divisions



BELATED AWAKENING

The army plans a major reorganisation as India moves to counter China's build-up on the borders

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

His visit to China may have been yawn-inducing, with the words couched in mealy-mouthed diplomatese, but Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's recent two-day visit to Arunachal Pradesh, where he announced a series of infrastructure projects, was far more significant. It sent out a subtle message that the Indian Government was finally acting to counter the threat on the country's eastern flank, not only because it was the first visit by a prime minister in over a decade to the state which China claims as 'lower Tibet', but one which quietly underlined a truism: it is a sovereign Indian territory that would not be bartered. The visit comes on the heels of the Defence Ministry's quiet build-up on the long-neglected North-

east. Just days before the prime minister left for China last month, the Cabinet Committee on Security approved the formation of two new mountain divisions for the Indian Army at a cost of Rs 650 crore each. In what will be the army's largest reorganisation in the North-east in decades, the divisions will comprise nearly 14,000 soldiers, functioning under the Kolkata-based Eastern Command. "These are the first moves being taken by the Government to prepare for any possible long-term threat from China," says a senior army official.

Reacting to reports of the rapid development of infrastructure on the Chinese side, the prime minister announced road and rail projects worth Rs 10,000 crore, including one for a lateral road running through the state. These projects will not only speed

up the development of one of India's most isolated states, but also bolster troop deployment in times of crisis. Manmohan tread carefully, gingerly skipping Tawang, which analysts say was a big mistake. "The Chinese understand their strength. The prime minister should have gone to Tawang, considering they have staked claim on the area," says Brigadier (retd) Gurmeet Kanwal, director, Centre for Land Warfare Studies (CLAWS).

Last month, the Government appointed former army chief General (retd) J.J. Singh as the Governor of Arunachal Pradesh—India's only state which borders three countries. On the surface, India is talking peace and cooperation with China—in December last year it held its first-ever joint military exercise with the People's Liberation Army Navy (PLAN) in